

Jupiter takes 12 Earth years to orbit the Sun.



As seen from space, the Earth's colour scheme comes from its land, oceans, and white clouds. Jupiter is painted in oranges by the clouds of chemicals in its atmosphere.

In a spin

Despite its size, Jupiter spins faster than any other planet. In fact, one rotation takes just under 10 hours. It spins so fast that it bulges slightly at the equator, and its clouds are pulled into thick bands.

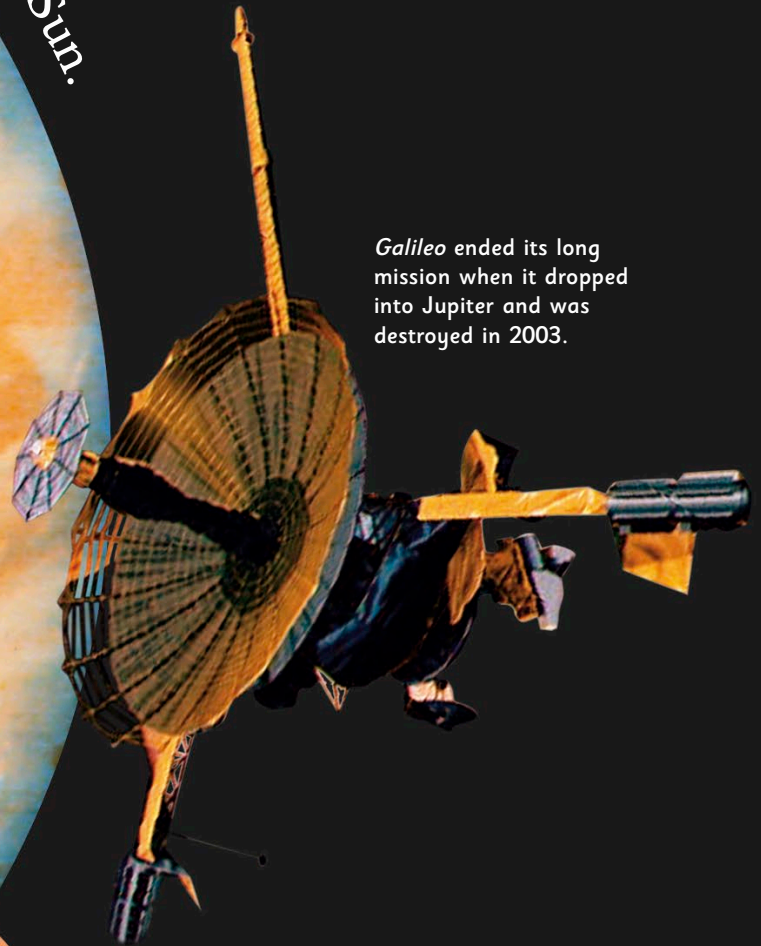
Let's take a closer look

The *Galileo* spacecraft reached Jupiter in 1995 and began to orbit the planet. It also dropped a probe into Jupiter's atmosphere. Before being destroyed after just 58 minutes in the intense heat and pressure, the probe sent back information about the planet.

This is Io, one of Jupiter's many moons orbiting the planet.

The probe entered Jupiter's atmosphere at 170,000 kph (106,000 mph). Its descent was slowed by a 2.5-m- (8-ft-) wide parachute.

The *Galileo* probe was about the size and weight of a fairly small cow.



Galileo ended its long mission when it dropped into Jupiter and was destroyed in 2003.

No stopping me now!

Galileo finished its main mission in 1997, but incredibly, it survived until 2003, sending back lots of extra information about Jupiter and its moons. You can discover more about Jupiter's moons on pages 68 and 69.

weird or what?

Jupiter is shrinking slightly each year because it is being squeezed by its gravity. The energy produced means it creates more heat than it gets from the Sun.